endeavouring to effect an entrance, and Burnes was trying to pacify them.' Johnson's account continues:

> Arose. Ordered my horse to be got ready, but before mounting went to report what I had heard to Captain Lawrence, Military Secretary to the Envoy. The latter had already received a note from Burnes on the subject and was on his way to the General's. Another of my servants then arrived to say the street in which Burnes and I lived was completely taken possession of by the mob. Some of them were trying to break open my gate, and my Treasury guard was keeping up a heavy fire upon them. Seeing my horse was saddled, he told me it would be impossible to reach my house, as the insurgents were increasing every minute, and were murdering any Europeans or Hindoostanees that came in their way. In the supposition that the General would immediately order down a detachment to suppress the tumult, as well as to save my Treasury and the life of the Resident, Sir Alexander Burnes, from whom another letter had been received *imploring immediate assistance*, my horse was kept ready that I might accompany the party. Went on the ramparts to see if anything towards the city indicated a disturbance. Had not been there five minutes before a dense smoke was seen rising and from its direction I was immediately convinced the rebels had set fire to my house. I also heard heavy vollies of musquet firing.

'Terrific reports . . . of murder and plunder' began to reach him.

> Yet to our astonishment no detachment was as yet ordered. Hours slipped away and no steps taken to quell the insurrection. A rumour was current, which afterwards proved but too true, that the insurgents had gained possession of my Treasury by mining the wall and of my house by setting fire to the gateway, that they had murdered the whole of the guard consisting of 1 Subadar and 28 Sepoys besides our [European] commissioned officers, all my servants – male, female, and children – had plundered the whole of my Treasury to the amount of about one lakh and seventy thousand rupees, burnt all my office records for the past 3 years, which comprise unadjusted accounts to nearly *one million* sterling, and had possessed themselves of all my private property amounting to upward of ten thousand rupees.[2]

Johnson could not believe that so little was being done to save Burnes or the treasury, or his staff, and made repeated enquiries as to what the plans were. It emerged that the problem lay with General Elphinstone. When reports came in that a disturbance had begun in the old city, the ailing General had tried for the first time since his arrival to mount his horse, but had fallen heavily, and the horse on him, after which, according to Captain Vincent Eyre, 'Elphinstone, who I fancy was never a strong or independent-minded man, was reduced to one remove from dotage.'[3]

One man in the cantonment who was trying to stir the troops into action was Macnaghten's energetic young Military Secretary George Lawrence. Like Johnson, Lawrence had been up early and had discovered that trouble